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Authoritarian power and contestation beyond the state

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ABSTRACT
Research on authoritarian connections beyond the state requires a transregional practices approach. This special issue is an invitation to combine critical approaches to the study of authoritarian power by paying attention to spaces of contestation, authoritarian practices, as well as non-state actors and agency below and beyond the scale of the state. We focus on *authoritarian practices* and their *spatial* and *temporal articulations* in (1) transregional infrastructures, (2) global processes of capital accumulation and (3) nature-society relations. This enables us to capture the diversity of authoritarian actors and the interconnectedness of authoritarian power and forms of contestation across time and space. Drawing on logistics and infrastructure literature, we reconcile the contextualization of power relations with multi-scalar authoritarian practices beyond the inside-outside binary of national territoriality. We thus offer a conceptual approach to understanding the violent and repressive practices inherent to a continuum of different political settings, including liberal governance.

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Introduction

The transregional connections of authoritarian power have become more and more obvious. Transregionally connected consumption patterns and unequal flows of goods and capital deliver the material basis for seemingly state-based authoritarian power. Even the current drive towards energy transition has in many contexts reinforced authoritarian power dynamics. Authoritarian discourses that have widely been perceived as nationalist campaign slogans (such as US President Trump's 'Make America Great Again') have travelled between regions (see Bolsonaro's and Duterte's 'Make Brazil Great Again' and 'Make the Philippines Great Again'). Private firms like American McKinsey and Israeli NSO Group have enabled crackdowns on and surveillance of oppositional activists in Saudi-Arabia, Mexico, Hungary and elsewhere (Business & Human Rights Resource Centre, 2021; England, 2018), and violence against environmental activists worldwide has increased (Collins, 2021). Also, the externalization of the authoritarian effects of EU and US migration regimes (Arteaga, 2017) towards Northern Africa or Central America point to important transregional connections. Yet, this inherently transnational and even transregional dimension is not immediately nor commonsensically associated with the term

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authoritarianism, as political debates seem to remain trapped in binaries of authoritarian versus democratic regimes.

This special issue calls on different strands of critical scholarship on authoritarian politics to engage with each other to address this problem. Its main objective is to offer an innovative perspective on how to think further transregional practices in authoritarian politics. We particularly invite political scientists researching authoritarian power to engage with the exciting work done in critical logistics, political geography, or global sociology, and to study authoritarian politics through an infrastructure lens. Simultaneously, we call on critical geography and STS scholars to engage more with political economy approaches to the state (see also Lawreniuk, 2022).

In our contribution, we propose a social-relational ontology of authoritarianism and argue that authoritarianism cannot and must not be analysed in isolation of the myriad of social relations that it is embedded in. The state is essential for the production and reproduction of authoritarian power. Building on Nicos Poulantzas (2002), we understand the state as a social relational entity in itself that mediates and regulates both state-society and nature-society relations. Different, sometimes even antagonistic social forces are found across state institutions, some with easier access than others, making the implementation of policies uneven and heterogeneous. Simultaneously, states assume a fundamental role in enabling capitalist relations of production in the long term. This relationality also means, however, that states are always embedded in global (power) relations; they are not self-contained, and that has consequences for our understanding of authoritarian power.

To think beyond the state, we suggest focusing on *authoritarian practices* and their *spatial* and *temporal articulations* in the context of (1) transregional infrastructures, (2) global processes of capital accumulation and (3) nature-society relations. The transnational and transregional connection and embeddedness of authoritarian practices hinders their contestation by social actors, as the current state of affairs does little in terms of acknowledging the need to continuously shift and rescale political action from the local to the global and back. We must grasp the 'dynamic nature of governance' (Glasius, 2018a), the contradictory power relations within and across national contexts and the very different experiences of authoritarian power, based on categories of class, race and gender. As others have done, we try to avoid methodological nationalism and what Agnew (1994) described as a 'territorial trap'. Notably, we aim to conceptualize the fact that the spatial manifestation of authoritarian power and the actions of authoritarian actors, as well as their effects, do not necessarily coincide with their physical presence (see also Koch, 2022).

To better grasp the complexity of contemporary authoritarian power, this special issue addresses the urgency to debate the following questions:

- How does a focus on transregional contexts help us shift our attention to a different set of authoritarian practices and forms of contestation, as well as different actors within and beyond the state?
- How does the consensual and the coercive manifest across different scales in the temporal and spatial (re-)articulation of authoritarian practices, in the context of transregional infrastructures, processes of capital accumulation and changing nature-society relations?

Thinking further: state of the art and contributions of this special issue

The main observation driving this special issue is that the state has become a globalized institution (Bogaert, 2018), despite its territorial anchoring. Yet, when the global nature of authoritarian power is acknowledged, it is largely done by understanding its effects as globalized, i.e. as a 'challenge presented by regimes in Moscow, Beijing, Tehran, Caracas, and Riyadh' (Diamond et al., 2016, p. 17).

Such approaches ignore the ways in which authoritarian power in itself is globally constituted across different geographies. Accordingly, our interest lies in authoritarian practices that emerge and manifest across space, scale, and different constituencies (Chomiak & Schwedler, 2019, p. 93; Luger, 2020). The critique of state- and regime-centric approaches is of course nowhere new (see Mitchell, 1991). Scholars have engaged with how processes of digitalization reshape existing authoritarian practices, and formally democratic, as well as openly authoritarian actors below and above the level of the state increasingly reinforce authoritarian power both at home and abroad (Brownlee, 2012; Schuetze, 2019; Tansey, 2016). Those implicated in this authoritarian turn, depending on the level and kind of radicalism, frequently deal with opponents by restrictive laws, but also, by openly promoting political imprisonment or physical violence, including fantasies of destruction and annihilation. The construction of such imageries of 'threat' is far from incidental, casual, or sporadic. In many cases, these phenomena are rooted in colonial patterns of domination and exploitation (Axster et al., 2021; Boatcă, 2021; Lowe, 2015), which continue to subsume certain ecologies and territories to the logics of capital accumulation (Moore, 2015). These spatial and historical dynamics are often based on processes of racialization, mediated by the appropriation and commodification of nature in ways that redefine and reorganize the politics of societal change (Fairhead et al., 2012). A closer look at these processes is necessary, since demands to replace the material basis of the global economy with cleaner and renewable sources of energy and raw materials open up spaces and pathways for the 'greening' of authoritarian practices, leading to coercive patterns of environmentalism (Li & Shapiro, 2020).

The challenge we face is to both focus on the state's internal contradictions and power struggles, and on the transnational political economies with which authoritarian power is intertwined. Established regime-based work on authoritarianism (Levitsky & Way, 2010; Linz, 2000; O'Donnell, 1999) aside, many scholars have made more differentiated and nuanced contributions. There is inspiring and diverse work on authoritarian power's territorial unboundedness (Glasius, 2018a, p. 179), its globalized nature (Bogaert, 2018), its transregional entanglements (Jenss & Schuetze, 2021) and its tendency to enable capital accumulation (Bruff & Tansel, 2019). Pitcher and Soares de Oliveira's special issue on 'Authoritarian Power in the Global Economy' (2022) explores the transnational reach of authoritarian power and global authoritarian linkages, but portrays the global economy as largely unproblematic, and merely open to exploitation by authoritarian elites (see Soares de Oliveira & Laporte, 2022). This perpetuates the impression that authoritarian power is a threat that emanates exclusively from authoritarian regimes. By focusing on transregional infrastructures, global processes of capital accumulation and nature-society relations, we show that global capitalism is driving authoritarian power, rather than being exploited by it. Growing global interconnectedness enables autocratic governments to pursue new strategies of transnational repression (Tsourapas, 2021), attempting to make the world 'safe for dictatorship' (Dukalskis, 2021). However, interconnectedness also reminds us of the need to look more closely at the multiple ways in which formally democratic actors are implicated in authoritarian practices.

This special issue is an invitation to 'think further' and combine existing critical approaches to the study of authoritarian power by paying attention to spaces of contestation, authoritarian practices, as well as non-state actors and agency below and beyond the scale of the state. Our invitation is to combine approaches that study transregional infrastructures, authoritarian neoliberalism and political economy, as well as nature-society relations, in order to analyse contemporary authoritarian practices beyond the state.

Transregional infrastructures: To grasp the complexities of contemporary authoritarian power, we rely on new starting points and/or notions of context, such as the logistics space (Cowen, 2014)

and infrastructural politics. An infrastructural lens into contemporary authoritarian power helps us reveal its inherently transnational/transregional dimension. For instance, the study of logistics (Chua, 2018; Cowen, 2014), or of 'planetary' mining infrastructures (Arboleda, 2020) reveal their global character, asking for agents that wield power across a variety of terrains and are unrestricted by state boundaries (Tyfield & Rodríguez, 2022), but whose (inter-)actions have specific effects on particular sites, i.e. place-based social arrangements.

Infrastructure, understood as 'critical locations through which sociality, governance and politics, accumulation and dispossession, and institutions and aspirations are formed, reformed, and performed' (Anand et al., 2018, p. 2), is an efficient means for the seemingly apolitical pursuit of deeply political objectives, as it stores within itself notions of technocratic inevitability and abstract desires (Larkin, 2013; Martínez & Sirri, 2020). It produces, enables and promises connections and creates forms of containment and isolation (Chua, 2018). It simultaneously triggers processes of territorialization and deterritorialization, but simultaneously, infrastructure may reveal 'counter-hegemonic' characteristics (Dajani & Mason, 2018, p. 131). Infrastructure and logistics literatures have analysed the reinforcement of hierarchized differences and the containment of human bodies (Chua, 2018; Cowen, 2014; Khalili, 2018; Ziadah, 2019), dynamics that can and should, as we suggest, be conceptualized as authoritarian. This way, we can expose the institutionalised nature of authoritarian power. Infrastructure literature analyses powerfully and convincingly transregionally connected forms of containment. But how do these operate in conjunction with institutions, and add up in a more institutionalized and cohesive form? Importantly, our focus on authoritarian power beyond the state does not mean 'without the state'. This special issue is also an invitation to scholars of logistics and infrastructure to engage with the growing body of literature on transnationally connected authoritarian practices.

The violence of infrastructure hides behind the production of selective connectivities, often based on categories of class and race (Appel, 2019), and a language full of dreams and abstract futurity that makes false promises about the merits of connectivity. In that regard, infrastructure reshapes and rearticulates political conflicts along new spatial and discursive borders that do not follow fixed territorial lines. Moreover, infrastructure is both the means via which authoritarian power can be reconfigured into new transregional/transnational or global configurations (Bogaert, 2018), and holds in itself an authoritarian potential that is premised on forms of selective inclusion, deliberate exclusion, containment and colonial continuities (Cupers, 2022). The latter become relevant inasmuch the structures of authoritarian power underpinning the long and enduring history of global capitalism have emerged out of and continue to rely upon the labour-disciplining and ecologically harmful rationales of colonial practices, patterns, and technologies. These include mines, plantations, ports, roads, bridges, as well as predictable, quantifiable and tradable sources of food and energy, which respond to old and new metrics of efficiency, productivity, and progress (Moore, 2003), which links to the next two foci of this special issue.

Global processes of capital accumulation: Authoritarian neoliberalism, a second body of literature we build on, and effectively a critical political economy lens, allows us to focus on the interrelations of political and economic factors, for instance, in practices that enable capital accumulation through coercive mechanisms that work to the detriment of democratic contestation. Authoritarian neoliberalism draws on Stuart Hall, Nicos Poulantzas, and Antonio Gramsci for critical readings of multi-scalar state practices in contemporary neoliberalization processes, but does *not* insinuate a (post-2009) rupture with earlier, allegedly less authoritarian neoliberal practices. It is not new to employ coercive practices in order to protect or enable capital accumulation, nor have earlier

processes of neoliberalization been purely based on consensus (Bruff & Tansel, 2019, n.p.; Tansel, 2017, pp. 2–3).

Yet the literature also refrains from ahistorical and reductionist views of capitalist statecraft as seamlessly authoritarian. It rather wishes to carve out the specific conjunctures and turning points at which, we can observe both the intertwinement of neoliberalization and authoritarian practices coming to the fore, and the transformation of workplaces, urban sites of interpersonal relations, or households via frequently coercive means and with anti-democratic effects within and from the context-specific logics i.e. political economy of neoliberalism (Bruff & Tansel, 2019). Commercialised and securitised forms of power, especially with regard to outright violence and state-based practices of coercion, including the increased reliance on policing can thus be grasped as part and parcel of such forms of neoliberalization (Jenss, 2020; Laub, 2021). The intrinsic link between neoliberal motives (such as deregulation, market liberalization, austerity, privatization) and authoritarian practices becomes obvious as the (failed) border wall project by the Trump administration has become a site for capital accumulation (Keck & Clúa-Losada, 2021), the anti-migration support for a border-industrial complex selectively targets the 'disruptive movements' of racialised people (Smith, 2019), and as legal regulations are mobilised to deter labour struggles across value chains (Lawreniuk, 2022). The impact of technological innovation, driven by the quest for new markets, on social relations at and across specific places has been studied for a long time (Pred & Watts, 1992), but the objective of upscaled control and discipline incites entirely new and oftentimes extraterritorial forms of mass surveillance, sometimes referred to as 'surveillance capitalism' (Zuboff, 2019). Such practices are fed by quests for making profit from the increasing commodification of personal data (Aho & Duffield, 2020). Surveillance as a means of authoritarian repression has thus not only curbed dissent, but also itself enabled capital accumulation during the thorough neoliberalization of political and economic relations worldwide.

Nature-society relations: As our two previous foci suggest, both the analysis of transregional infrastructures and their entanglement with capital accumulation hinge upon intense and violent transformations of nature-society relations (Moore, 2015). Dystopian images of current and future ecological breakdown accompany calls to end fossil fuel extraction and to reinvent global energy flows away from highly polluting and unequally distributed materials. As the climate crisis intensifies, current forms of industrial production, the land- and water-intensive footprint of the agricultural practices sustaining global food systems, as well as the exclusiveness and high-carbon qualities of current mobility regimes seem at best obsolete. However, different forms of resistance against the alienating effects associated with the profit-driven and forceful appropriation of non-human natures in the form of arable land for monocultures, hydropower, photovoltaic or wind sources (Backhouse et al., 2019; Backhouse & Lehmann, 2020), are routinely met with 'soft' and 'hard' technologies of intimidation, coercive measures, and even outright violence by state and non-state actors alike (Appel, 2019; Dunlap, 2021). Research on how socio-ecological transitions are managed across continents has pointed to the advent of an authoritarian type of 'climate necropolitics': a multiscalar field of contestation in which transregional practices, discourses, and logics of ecological intervention justify violence in the name of climate change (DeBoom, 2021). Others point to the 'dark side' of mining for renewable energies (Kramarz et al., 2021) on a planetary scale (Arboleda, 2020). This work calls attention to the fact that the extraction of minerals to support technological changes towards the electrification of industrial production, e-mobility, and renewable energy artefacts, perpetuates, instead of easing pre-existing processes of land dispossession, degradation, and conflict in the regions where extraction takes place. In line with the literature on the coloniality of nature (Alimonda, 2019), the extraction of minerals or the appropriation of land are not to be understood

as ahistorical and apolitical transactions on the so-called 'free-markets', as argued by the neoliberal defenders of contemporary globalization. Instead, these processes of 'infrastructuring' nature are entwined with attempts at 'ecologising' capital (Tyfield & Rodríguez, 2022). The latter, in turn, respond to social relations of violence and power, which have been historically mediated by colonial modes of appropriating and subordinating nature (Alimonda, 2019).

These forms of 'pro-capitalist violence' (Hristov, 2021), are enacted via appropriations of both non-human nature and human labour, and hence structurally, legally but also ideologically embedded in state-society relations. At times, agro-ecological transitions based on the shift away from illicit crops in rural areas affected by 'the war on drugs', have instead prompted the 'corporate greening' of private firms and brought about non-armed forms of 'slow violence' through aerial fumigations with poisoning effects on local livelihoods (Veelen et al., 2021). Indeed, a largely unexplored system of ideological, political, or even organizational interconnections in producing nature-society relations stretches from the local to the global. This resonates with earlier work that focuses on everyday security practices of transnational mining companies (Hönke, 2014) and corporate strategies that 'domesticate dissent' around oil field concessions (Montesinos Coleman, 2013). Yet it also points to the fact that the ongoing intensification of extraction and the enforced building of electricity infrastructures are connected to authoritarian practices that now more than ever move beyond national borders, intertwining and enabling cycles of capital accumulation across different scales. For instance, the maintenance of cyberspace relies upon the stable flow of electricity sources that must be generated somewhere, hence connecting the digital sphere with multiscalar conflicts around the social and biophysical boundaries of an only seemingly deterritorialized space of repression and contestation.

This special issue is an invitation to re-examine which of these corporate practices actually have authoritarian effects, disabling contestation and prefiguring political outcomes, and how they may have transformed during the last decade of increased investment in resource extraction for renewables.

Spatial and temporal articulations of authoritarian practices: transregional infrastructures, capital accumulation and nature-society relations

This special issue discusses authoritarianism through a focus on transnational and multiscalar practices. Doing so enables us to better capture the diversity of authoritarian actors and the interconnectedness of spatial and temporal articulations of authoritarian power and forms of contestation. Hence, our understanding of authoritarian power is a social-relational one that consists of different authoritarian practices that can be articulated temporally and spatially across different scales. We offer a conceptual approach that helps to capture the violent and repressive practices inherent in a continuum of different political settings, including liberal governance. In that regard, authoritarian power is not only understood as sabotaging a form of pre-existing accountability (Glasius, 2018b, p. 517), but also as preventing 'demanded forms of accountability via strategies of preemption, technocratization, and coercion' (Jenss & Schuetze, 2021, p. 83). Authoritarian practices cut across time and space; They are mobilized through state space and territorial boundaries in certain spatio-temporal contexts, and transcend it in others. Drawing on the (indirect) perspective on authoritarian power offered by logistics and infrastructure literature, we seek to reconcile the contextualization of power relations with multi-scalar authoritarian practices beyond the 'inside/outside binary of national territoriality' (Cowen, 2014, p. 11) and the binary of national vs. global. Authoritarian 'extraterritorial practices' (Glasius, 2018a) are not only entrenched in the activities of regimes in their respective diasporas, but may involve private and corporate actors, or investment and logistics

circuits. While we recognize that authoritarian power always becomes spatialized in one way or another, we emphasize that the presence or absence of authoritarian actors cannot always be mapped into concrete spatial units. Here, we build on Massey's (1991, p. 27) call to stop thinking 'of places as areas with boundaries around, [but] as articulated moments in networks of social relations and understandings'.

Similar to Glasius (2018b, p. 179), we understand authoritarianism as territorially unbounded 'mode[s] of governing people', but focus on governing practices specifically at globally connected infrastructure hubs and logistics circuits, such as transnational electricity grids, and on the sites where nature-society relations are visibly and radically changing, such as mines. We are interested in how such practices interact with, and are driven by, the quest for and the contradictions of global capital accumulation. For instance, authoritarian practices, as we understand them, interact with the pressures to intensify both the extraction of minerals and the exploitation of labouring bodies (Bieler & Nowak, 2021). The added value of a practice-based reading of authoritarian power is that it helps us take into account a broader range of actors that may have scalar reach beyond the state, or be relegated to a more local realm, but all possess agency in some form or another. The following two sections specify how we understand authoritarian practices as manifesting temporally or spatially in the context of processes of capital accumulation, transregional infrastructures and nature-society relations (for other approaches to the spatial and temporal dimensions of authoritarian power see Chomiak & Schwedler, 2019, and Conduit, 2020).

Temporal articulations of authoritarian practices

Rather than a top-down approach to state institutions, we insist to take contradictory social relations and political struggles as a starting point, in order to analyse state practices that end up shielding the quest for profit from contestation. In doing so, we draw and expand on the concept of authoritarian neoliberalism (Bruff & Tansel, 2019). Rather than turning away from the state as a key organizational structure, it is our focus on the global production of the state, which we add to this literature. A range of state and non-state actors – rather than just state representatives – wield political agency in pushing for investment, the construction of large-scale infrastructures, or the intensified commodification of societal realms previously organized according to communal parameters. The infrastructure and logistics literatures focus on mobility and containment through the prism of global capital flows (Chua, 2018, p. 13). They allow us to see how the tensions between the global circulation of capital and goods, and the parallel containment of bodies result in preemptive and calculative practices, but also in strategies of concrete repression that (re-)organize space and social life.

Authoritarian practices may involve the acceleration of and changes in work rhythms, which complicate the possibilities of workers to unionize. Temporal aspects also come to the fore when we observe how workers' organizations and social movements, i.e. in the logistics sector, employ the temporal instrument of disrupting the transnational flow of goods by blocking road access, or by organizing a strike. The objective of the seamlessness of logistics flows (Cowen, 2014) has even led corporations to perceive strike action as a temporal threat in that it can slow down the flow of goods. In some contexts of accelerated cycles of accumulation, inhabitants are unable to participate in political negotiations that define their place of living, but only experience the brutal externalization of its negative, violent effects, for instance through forced displacement or the appropriation of land (Jenss, 2020). Vice versa, accelerated rhythms of accumulation have changed our everyday practices, and simultaneously, given new urgency to contestation such as

protests against minerals extraction. In other contexts, the 'slow' violence of processes like gentrification is only partially countered by processes of neighbourhood organization, and even less, by politics of care.

Practices of democratic contestation may then be presented as a matter of delay only, by proponents of investment projects. Authoritarian practices include the inhibition of protest and its presentation as anti-progress, stuck in the past, or development-unfriendly. They reduce democracy to its procedural aspects, and risk that a perception of elections as little more than repetitive rituals and performance, becomes widespread. However, large-scale projects also prefigure politics. Their large-scale set-up can risk removing the negotiation around essential infrastructures from possibilities for democratic contestation. In many cases, the construction of connectivity facilities builds on and revitalizes patterns of colonial disciplining and racialized exploitation, which the ruling and privileged classes paradoxically justify as a societal break with 'backwardness' and a temporal move (forward) towards efficiency and progress. We understand these temporal aspects of authoritarian practices to be intimately articulated with their spatial aspects, which foregrounds the unevenness of their effects. The articles in the collection each in their way deal with moments of articulation of temporal and spatial aspects of authoritarian practices.

Spatial articulations – or looking for authoritarianism where others have not

Paradoxically, authoritarian practices that cut across established notions of space may incite new and creative forms of resistance and the articulation of organized protest across borders. The sites where these practices are articulated spatially, may not be the conventional ones usually associated with political power like parliaments, ministries, or the central plazas. Instead, we encourage scholars to look for authoritarianism where others have not. For instance, the transport of energy is key for capital accumulation, and disciplining practices in the logistics sector are part and parcel of authoritarian neoliberalism. Likewise, the mine is an emblematic site where changing nature-society relations, ecological damage, and the practices wielded to discipline alternative approaches to nature converge, pushed by transnational alliances of actors within and beyond the state. The electricity grid, for instance, consists of a series of sites that materialize social relations in terms of energy inequality, land ownership, and access to knowledge, and embodies past promises of modern, democratic societies.

One important element in that regard is (physical and digital) infrastructure. Not only does infrastructure contribute to advancing, stabilizing or (re)producing authoritarian power, it also enables new forms of contestation and resistance. Hence, we follow a dual understanding of infrastructure simultaneously as a tool for exerting and stabilizing authoritarian power that enables the transregional diffusion of certain authoritarian practices (Gurol & Schuetze, 2022), but also as enabling (transregionally connected) new forms of resistance or contestation (Van Veelen et al., 2021). As infrastructure has become an increasingly popular means for the reinforcement of authoritarian power, we will likely see the emergence of corresponding counter-infrastructures as a new mode of resistance, reminding us of the ambivalences and potentially unintended consequences that are always associated with the reconfiguration of modes of power (Gurol & Schuetze, 2022). We thereby speak to the existing scholarship on the different ways in which violence can manifest in interactions around infrastructural expansion or the intensification of extraction (Allan et al., 2021; Dunlap, 2021; Kramarz et al., 2021).

Processes of depoliticization, decontextualization and technocratisation are a crucial component of authoritarian power, as they turn deeply political questions about the uneven

distribution of power into seeming problems of technocratic management (Ferguson, 1994; Mitchell, 2002). They thereby create the necessary space and the practical distance that allows for the emergence of universally deployable experts, whose interventions regularly exacerbate authoritarian dynamics instead of challenging them. Processes of technocratisation – at times directly supported by various international actors and originating in formally democratic states – have been key to the reproduction of authoritarian power in Jordan (Schuetze, 2019), Morocco (Cavatorta, 2016), Egypt (Brownlee, 2012) and Palestine (El Kurd, 2020). Against this backdrop, transregional connections beyond the state make local manifestations of authoritarian power harder to contest when its transnational and multiscalar dynamics remain unexposed, as the addressee of protest becomes more diffuse. Just as infrastructure reconfigures pre-existing and creates new forms of containment behind a façade of global connectivity, so does contemporary authoritarian power present itself via formally democratic state-based procedures and institutions (Lust-Okar, 2006). These only barely hide/draw attention away from the multiple authoritarian connections beyond the state, which are effectively forming a new phenomenon of transregionalised twenty-first century neoliberal authoritarianism.

We highlight the interconnectedness of authoritarian practices and global processes of capital accumulation (Bruff & Tansel, 2019) and complement established focuses on authoritarian power with analyses of corporate actors that drive an authoritarian shift in new contexts both within and beyond the state (Jenss & Schuetze, 2021). Based on our understanding of the role of global capital flows for advancing authoritarian practices, we argue that encompassing accounts of transregional authoritarian power need to take into account changing nature-society relations, as human and extra-human natures are dialectically bound with authoritarian processes and practices of capital accumulation (Moore, 2015). Particularly in and through the production of political responses to ongoing ecological crises, the sites of extraction, and the sites where ecological damage becomes visible, are emblematic for authoritarian practices. Questioning how climate emergency and the need to decarbonize the global economy relate to authoritarian power, and attempts at resisting it, is thus fundamental to our approach.

Structure of the special issue

The contributions of this special issue explore how authoritarian practices are articulated spatially and temporally across different scales. In doing so, they scrutinize processes of capital accumulation, changing nature-society relations and transregional infrastructures. The empirical focus lies on the authoritarian practices that shape (and are reconfigured by) transregional infrastructures, global circuits of capital accumulation and nature-society relations within and beyond China, Peru, Central America, Morocco and the EU, Serbia, Turkey, Brazil, while pointing to spatial and temporal connections in and across these spaces, as well as between France, China, and Cameroon. In conjunction, the articles deliver a cross-regional mapping of seemingly dispersed cases of (and experiences with) authoritarianism, showing how the latter takes shape in a globally interconnected setting beyond the state.

The special issue begins with a conceptualization of authoritarian neoliberalism and authoritarian practices in the digital age, by *Koray Saglam*. Developing the notion of a 'digital blender', he argues that authoritarian practices are not only enabled by new technologies, but actually incentivize them, thereby drawing on a mutually reinforcing relationship between (in this case digital) infrastructures and authoritarian practices.

Ruben Gonzalez-Vicente addresses China's present 'de-revolutionary' moment, which is characterized by a nationalist understanding of development. While the PCR's domestic development trajectory shows a lot of similarities to traits of authoritarianism and neoliberalism found elsewhere, it still shows two distinct aspects in its approach. For one, it operates in a piecemeal fashion, promoting project-specific policy arrangements rather than durable policy change. Secondly, it justifies the deployment of multi-scalar and transnational forms of authoritarian power with a discourse of national(ist) sovereignty that enables national policy elites to govern and discipline people and nature in the name of the nation and for the benefit of capital.

This connects to *Fabricio Rodríguez* and *César Bazán Seminario's* article that explores the ways state-capital flows from China interact with and benefit from previously established policing institutions and anti-terror systems designed to defend and safeguard neoliberal growth formulas in Peru. Dissecting the multiscalar dynamics of authoritarian power, the authors highlight the practices of state coercion that enable Chinese corporations to extract copper resources from the Indigenous highlands of Peru through an emerging phenomenon of 'para-coloniality'.

Alke Jenss and *Benjamin Schuetze* bring together literature on technopolitics and authoritarian practices to develop a conceptual approach to how transregional energy infrastructure projects prefigure and limit politics. They propose an understanding of authoritarian power as transregionally interlinked, which enables an exploration of the multiple entanglements between various actors. Transregional infrastructures shift the field of struggles into a seemingly actor-less realm, where contestation becomes difficult. Simultaneously, these infrastructures are increasingly embedded in containment infrastructures that aim at deterring migration.

Aleksandra Piletić gives another example of the entanglements between energy projects and authoritarianism. Her paper explores the multiscalar pathways of authoritarian neoliberal restructuring in the Balkans by focusing on the region's recent efforts to transition to more renewable forms of energy. *Piletić* explores how the EU has exerted a coercive influence on EU candidate countries. The mandatory implementation of the EU energy acquis communautaire in the Balkans has intertwined both with disarticulated authoritarian practices across the region, as well as more concerted efforts to entrench national authoritarian regimes, legitimizing and further empowering actors like Serbian president Vučić and his clientelist networks.

Ayşegül Can and *Hugo Fanton* showcase in their article how neoliberal and transnational capital collaborates with authorities in increasingly closed political environments, and how local and national authorities engage with urban neoliberalism in a selective manner, while keeping their grip on power. To do so, they elaborate on the dominant contemporary patterns of urban spatial production in Istanbul and São Paulo. The paper discusses how the notion of neoliberal authoritarian urbanism is important to understand the current phase of capital accumulation in two cities of the Global South that are experiencing crises of liberal democracy, and the rise of authoritarianism as a common denominator.

Basile Ndjio discusses how authoritarian power has shaped the postcolonial state in Cameroon, demonstrating the ways in which external powers such as France and China have nurtured this process, both in material and ideational terms. While recognizing that the state continues to set much of the terms of reference for violent action and other forms of repression, the authoremphasizes the need to revisit discussions about authoritarianism beyond state-centric, ahistorical approaches. In doing so, *Ndjio* proposes the concept of 'rhizomatic autocracy', which he understands as a complex network of connections, coalitions and alliances that tie together local, regional, national and transnational actors, institutions and agencies.

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